7. Making food last — without a fridge and long term (English)

Oracle OS guide (USDA/FoodSafety.gov, FAO, USDA Complete Guide to Home Canning in the library).

During a power cut

- Keep fridge and freezer **closed**: fridge ≈ **4 hours** cold; full freezer ≈ **48 hours** (half full ≈ 24 hours).
- Eat fridge food first, then freezer, then tins.
- Discard meat, fish, eggs, dairy, cooked leftovers and sauces kept **above 4 °C (40 °F) for over 2 hours**. When in doubt, throw it out — never taste to test.
- Frozen food that still has ice crystals or is at 4 °C or below can be refrozen.

Long-life pantry (rotate: oldest first)

Rice, pasta, flour, oats, dried beans/lentils/chickpeas, tins, oil, salt, sugar, honey, powdered/UHT milk, tea/coffee, nuts, crackers, peanut butter, dried fruit, vitamins. Cool, dry, dark, sealed against damp, insects and rodents.

Traditional preservation

- **Drying** fruit, vegetables, herbs, thin strips of lean meat in sun and wind or dry heat, under insect netting.
- **Salting** fish/meat in coarse salt, then drying; soak before cooking.
- **Smoking**: low heat + smoke + drying; use non-resinous hardwood.
- **Fermenting**: cabbage/vegetables with **2–3% of their weight in salt**, packed under brine, 18–22 °C for 1–4 weeks; should smell sour, not rotten; discard coloured mould, slime or foul smell.
- **Pickling** in vinegar of at least 5% acidity; **sugar** (jams).
- **Natural cold**: cellar or pit for potatoes, carrots, apples, squash, onions; **zeer pot** (pot in pot with wet sand) cools by evaporation in dry climates.
- **Fat**: cooked meat sealed under lard (confit) keeps for weeks somewhere cool.

Home canning — botulism warning

High-acid foods (fruit, acidified tomatoes, pickles, jams): boiling water bath. **Low-acid foods (vegetables, beans, meat, fish, soups) only in a pressure canner** — a water bath does not kill *Clostridium botulinum*. Use tested times (USDA guide). Discard bulging, leaking, spurting or foul-smelling jars without tasting.

Signs of spoilage

Sour or rotten smell, slime, mould, swollen/seam-dented/rusty cans, domed lids.